Food Assistance Programs in Singapore (2026)

by chung chinyi | Jan 11, 2026 | Uncategorized | 0 comments

Singapore faces significant food insecurity despite its economic development. According to The Hunger Report by Singapore Management University's Lien Centre for Social Innovation, 10.4% of households experienced food insecurity at least once within 12 months in 2020, and up to 30% of people over 50 may not get enough to eat each day. This review covers major food assistance programs, their contact details, registration processes, and food offerings.

1. WILLING HEARTS

Overview

Willing Hearts is an IPC registered charity run mostly by volunteers that prepares and delivers about 10,000 daily meals to needy and marginalized people in Singapore, operating 365 days a year.

Contact Details

- **Address:** No. 1 Lorong J Telok Kurau (entrance via Joo Chiat Place), Singapore 425792
- **Phone:** +65 6476 5822
- **Email:**
- **Website:** willinghearts.org.sg
- **Operating Hours:** Daily, year-round

How to Register

Applicants need a social worker or social agency to apply on their behalf. Contact:

- Social Service Offices (SSO) ComCare hotline: 1800 222 0000
- Agency of Integrated Care (AIC): 1800 656 0505

Direct collection is also available at their soup kitchen during distribution times.

Food Types Offered

Hot, freshly prepared meals with Asian flavors, typically rice with 2-3 dishes including protein, vegetables, and curry or sauce. Meals prepared with consideration for various dietary needs and cultural preferences.

Distribution

Over 70 locations island-wide, with meals delivered daily to beneficiaries including the elderly, disabled, low-income families, and migrant workers.

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2. THE FOOD BANK SINGAPORE

Overview

Founded in 2012, The Food Bank Singapore aims to end food insecurity by 2025 through collecting surplus food and delivering it to those in need.

Contact Details

- **Address:** 218 Pandan Loop, XPACE, Singapore 128408
- **Phone:** +65 9855 4805
- **Email:**
- **Website:** www.foodbank.sg
- **Online Registration:** Available for volunteers; newsletter sign-up for Junior Foodbankers

How to Register

The Food Support Program provides essential food supplies to families and individuals facing food insecurity by distributing monthly food rations. Contact directly via email or phone for assistance.

Food Types Offered

Fresh produce (fruits and vegetables), frozen items (meat, seafood), dry goods (rice, pasta, canned foods), and dairy products.

Key Programs

- **Food Support Program:** Monthly food rations
- **Food Pantry 2.0:** 24/7 emergency food aid program utilizing automated vending machines. Beneficiaries receive bank cards loaded with credits to select food items at any time
- **Bank Card Programme:** Currently on pause, will relaunch in 2026

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3. FOOD FROM THE HEART

Overview

Founded in February 2003 by Singapore-based Austrian couple Henry and Christine Laimer, Food from the Heart is an IPC status food bank serving close to 64,000 beneficiaries across Singapore.

Contact Details

- **Address:** 130 Joo Seng Road, #03-01, Singapore 368357
- **Email:**
- **Website:** www.foodfromtheheart.sg
- **Volunteer Registration:** Available online through volunteer portal

How to Register

Food from the Heart works with social service agencies and community organizations. Contact your nearest Family Service Centre or speak with a social worker. Referrals will be made to Food from the Heart if you qualify.

Food Types Offered

Five distribution programs:

1. **Bread Run:** Surplus bread from bakeries and hotels
2. **Food Support:** Monthly food rations for lower-income individuals and families
3. **Community Shop:** Shop-for-free charity minimart
4. **School Breakfast Program:** Nourishment for underprivileged children
5. **Food Rescue:** Near-expiry and packaging-damaged food

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4. SINGAPORE BUDDHIST WELFARE SERVICES (SBWS)

Overview

Launched in 1985, the Daily Free Meal Delivery Programme provides free, healthy, vegetarian food to needy elderly and the vulnerable who face difficulties in getting their own meals, serving beyond differentiation, regardless of race or religion.

Contact Details

- **Phone:** +65 6489 8161
- **Website:** www.sbws.org.sg
- **Admin Office Hours:** 9:00am to 4:00pm (Closed on Saturdays, Sundays, and Public Holidays)

How to Register

Applications are accepted through referrals by hospitals, family service centres, grassroots organisations, and public agencies.

Food Types Offered

Vegetarian meals sent to beneficiaries twice a day, on a daily basis from Mondays to Saturdays (except Sundays and public holidays).

Traditional vegetarian Buddhist cuisine including mixed vegetable dishes, tofu preparations, and rice-based meals.

Additional Assistance

Public Assistance Programme provides Monthly Financial Assistance in the form of cash grants and/or Monthly Food Rations, based on needs assessed through home visits every 6 months.

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5. GOVERNMENT PROGRAMS – COMCARE

Overview

ComCare offers support to Singaporeans and their families who require financial assistance to meet basic needs like food, transport, and household bills.

Contact Details

- **ComCare Hotline:** 1800 222 0000
- **Website:** www.msf.gov.sg/comcare
- **Social Service Offices (SSO) Hours:**
  - Mon to Fri: 9am to 1pm (last registration at 12pm), 2pm to 6pm (last registration at 5pm)
  - Closed on Sat, Sun and Public Holidays

How to Register

Visit SupportGoWhere (supportgowhere.life.gov.sg) to:

- Find support schemes relevant to you
- Check eligibility
- Submit online application

Alternatively, visit your nearest Social Service Office for in-person assessment.

Types of Assistance

1. **Short-to-Medium-Term Assistance:** For those unable to work temporarily (illness, caregiving), job-seeking, or earning low income. Typically granted for 3-6 months.
2. **Long-Term Assistance:** For persons permanently unable to work due to age, illness, or disability.
3. **Emergency Assistance:** Immediate financial relief for urgent needs.

Eligibility

The applicant must be a Singapore Citizen or Permanent Resident (where at least one immediate family member of the same household is a Singapore Citizen). Income criteria are not hard thresholds—SSOs assess circumstances holistically.

Food Support

- Supermarket vouchers
- Cooked-food coupons
- Food packs

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6. SINGAPORE RED CROSS – MEALS WITH LOVE

Overview

The Singapore Red Cross Meals with Love Programme provides a stop-gap measure while families work with social workers to develop comprehensive long-term care plans.

Contact Details

- **Website:** redcross.sg/meals-with-love

- Contact through Singapore Red Cross main channels

How to Register

Applications are reviewed based on financial action plans. Referrals typically come through social workers and partner agencies like Thye Hua Kwan Charities (THK).

Food Support Offered

Identified families receive grocery vouchers for six months to purchase nutritious food and groceries including chicken, beef, vegetables, rice, and other necessities.

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7. THYE HUA KWAN MORAL CHARITIES – DORCAS PROGRAMME

Overview

Supports frail and homebound Singaporeans and Permanent Residents aged 55 and above.

Contact Details

- **Service Areas:** East and South Singapore
- **Email:**
- **Website:** thkmc.org.sg

How to Register

Contact via email for assessment. Services provided through professional staff and trained volunteers.

Food Types Offered

Daily hot meals for homebound seniors unable to buy or prepare meals, with well-being checks during delivery.

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8. COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT COUNCIL (CDC) VOUCHERS

Overview

CDC Vouchers can be used at participating hawker centers, supermarkets, and other food establishments, providing direct support for food expenses.

How to Access

Distributed to eligible households by the government. Check with your local CDC or through PA community centers for voucher schemes.

Usage

Can be used for food purchases at:

- Participating hawker centers
- Supermarkets
- Heartland shops

- Provision shops

ADDITIONAL FOOD ASSISTANCE PROGRAMS

9. Religious & Community Centers

Mosques & Islamic Centers:

- **MUIS (Islamic Religious Council of Singapore):** Iftar packs during Ramadan, Zakat distributions
- Various mosques run gotong-royong food distributions during festivals

Buddhist Temples:

- Free vegetarian meals and buffets at various temples
- Community kitchen programs

Hindu Temples & Sikh Temples:

- Free vegetarian meals during festivals (Deepavali, Vaisakhi)
- Daily langar (free kitchen) services at Gurdwaras

Christian Churches:

- Food pantries and meal programs
- Soup kitchens operated by various denominations

10. Community Fridges & Pantries

How to Find:

- Check local Facebook groups and Telegram channels
- Follow grassroots organizations
- Visit community centers for locations

Food Available:

- Donated fresh produce
- Packaged goods
- Baked items
- Ready-to-eat meals (varies by location)

11. University & College Student Support

For Students:

- Campus welfare services provide food packs
- Subsidized meals at student canteens
- Emergency vouchers for students in financial need

Contact:

- Student affairs offices
- Campus counseling centers
- Student unions

12. Free Food For All (FFFA)

Description: A registered charity providing halal meals to those in need while minimizing food waste. Started in 2014 at Darul Aman Mosque, FFFA has expanded services across multiple communities.

How to Access:

- Pop-up community pantries
- Distribution announcements on social media
- Various community locations

13. The Saturday Movement

Contact:

- **Email:**
- Founded in 2011 as a ground-up initiative

Focus: Weekend food distribution when other agencies don't operate, tackling food waste while supporting vulnerable populations.

14. Neighborhood Links & Family Service Centres

How They Help:

- Assess needs and make referrals
- Connect to appropriate food programs
- Provide holistic family support

Find Your Nearest Centre:

- Visit NCSS website (ncss.gov.sg)
- Call MSF hotline: 1800 111 2222
- Check at community centers

HOW TO ACCESS FOOD ASSISTANCE EFFICIENTLY

Step 1: Determine Urgency

- **Immediate Need:** Visit hospital social services, SSO, or Willing Hearts
- **Regular Support:** Contact Family Service Centre for assessment

Step 2: Gather Documentation

Prepare:

- NRIC/FIN
- Income proof (payslips, CPF statements)
- Medical reports (if applicable)
- Household bills

Step 3: Get Referrals

Most formal programs require referrals from:

- Social workers
- Family Service Centres
- Hospital social services
- Community nurses
- Grassroots leaders

Step 4: Multiple Sources

You can access:

- Government assistance (ComCare)
- Charity programs (Willing Hearts, Food Bank)
- Religious organization support
- Community pantries

Simultaneously, as different programs serve different needs.

Step 5: Stay Informed

- Subscribe to charity newsletters
- Join local community WhatsApp/Telegram groups
- Check FoodConnect Directory: foodconnect.gov.sg/directory
- Use 211 Singapore resource directory

PRACTICAL TIPS

General Etiquette

1. **Bring containers:** Many programs require own bags/containers
2. **Arrive early:** Popular distributions are first-come-first-served
3. **Respect guidelines:** Resources are limited, follow volunteer instructions
4. **Maintain dignity:** Assistance is confidential through official channels

Best Times to Visit

- **Willing Hearts:** Check daily distribution schedules
- **Temple meals:** Usually lunch and dinner times
- **Community pantries:** Weekends and evenings

- **Religious festivals:** Ramadan, Deepavali, Christmas for special distributions

Transport Support

If mobility is a challenge:

- Request home delivery (many programs offer this)
- Contact AIC for transport assistance: 1800 650 6060
- Use ComCare for transport vouchers

ELIGIBILITY GUIDELINES

Who Qualifies?

Most programs serve:

- Low-income households (typically under $3,000 per capita monthly income)
- Elderly unable to prepare meals
- Persons with disabilities
- Unemployed or underemployed
- Single-parent families
- Families facing temporary crisis

Citizenship Requirements

- **Government programs:** Singapore Citizens, PRs (with SC family member)
- **Charity programs:** Generally open to all residents, including non-citizens
- **Religious centers:** Usually no restrictions

VOLUNTEER & DONATION OPPORTUNITIES

All programs welcome:

- **Volunteers:** Kitchen help, food packing, delivery, administrative
- **Food donations:** Non-perishable items, fresh produce (check guidelines)
- **Monetary donations:** Tax-deductible for IPC charities
- **Corporate partnerships:** Bulk donations, CSR programs

FOOD TYPES SUMMARY BY PROGRAM

Program	Food Type	Frequency	Delivery Available
Willing Hearts	Hot Asian meals	Daily	Yes (70+ points)
Food Bank SG	Dry goods, fresh produce, frozen	Monthly rations	Through partners

Program	Food Type	Frequency	Delivery Available
Food from the Heart	Bread, groceries, food packs	Daily/Monthly	Limited
SBWS	Vegetarian meals	Twice daily (Mon-Sat)	Yes
ComCare	Vouchers for any food	As needed	N/A (vouchers)
Red Cross	Supermarket vouchers	6 months	N/A (vouchers)
CDC	Vouchers	Periodic	N/A (vouchers)

DIRECTORY OF KEY CONTACTS

Emergency Food Assistance

- **ComCare Hotline:** 1800 222 0000
- **AIC:** 1800 650 6060
- **MSF:** 1800 111 2222

Major Food Charities

- **Willing Hearts:** +65 6476 5822
- **Food Bank SG:** +65 9855 4805
- **Food from the Heart:**
- **SBWS:** +65 6489 8161

Online Resources

- **FoodConnect Directory:** foodconnect.gov.sg/directory
- **SupportGoWhere:** supportgowhere.life.gov.sg
- **NCSS Social Service Finder:** ncss.gov.sg
- **MSF ComCare:** msf.gov.sg/comcare

ADDITIONAL RECOMMENDED PROGRAMS

Based on current needs, Singapore should consider:

1. **Expanded Community Fridge Network**

Model after successful international programs with refrigerated units in accessible locations.

2. **Food Rescue Mobile Apps**

Real-time notifications for surplus food availability from restaurants and supermarkets.

3. **Workplace Food Assistance**

Programs for working poor who may not qualify for traditional assistance but struggle with food costs.

4. **Senior Meal Delivery Expansion**

More comprehensive coverage for homebound elderly, especially in underserved areas.

5. **Migrant Worker Food Programs**

Dedicated programs for foreign workers facing food insecurity.

6. **School Meal Programs**

Subsidized or free breakfast/lunch for low-income students during term time.

7. **Night Distribution Points**

For shift workers and those unable to access daytime services.

8. **Cultural-Specific Food Banks**

Programs catering to dietary requirements of different communities (halal, vegetarian, kosher).

CONCLUSION

Singapore has a robust network of food assistance programs combining government support, established charities, religious organizations, and grassroots initiatives. While 10.4% of surveyed households faced food insecurity at least once within a 12-month period in 2020, the expanding range of services aims to ensure no one goes hungry.

The key to accessing help is awareness, early contact with Family Service Centres or Social Service Offices, and understanding that multiple forms of assistance can be accessed simultaneously. All programs maintain confidentiality and aim to preserve dignity while providing essential support.

Last Updated: January 2025
Note: Program details, contact information, and operating hours may change. Always verify directly with organizations before visiting.

For immediate food assistance needs, call ComCare: 1800 222 0000

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